
Introduction

In the design phase, you have already encountered theoretical insights into the transdisciplinary learning process, including an overview of possible working methods. Now these ideas must be put into practice. You need to make choices and start testing.

The **theory page** of this torch discusses different perspectives on this learning process.

Theory

Iterative Learning

As previously quoted, in transdisciplinarity, it's the journey that matters most. This also applies to how we learn within a project. Transdisciplinary learning is **iterative learning**. When tackling complex problems, iterative learning is the only way forward. Due to the multifaceted and ever-changing nature of such problems, you must regularly revisit the issue and reconsider the action plan throughout the project.

Transformative Learning

Transformative learning involves changing one's beliefs about oneself and the world by critically examining received and underlying assumptions (Mezirow, 1981). This can be done by exposing oneself to alternative viewpoints and experiences, combined with deep reflection on one's worldviews and assumptions. Transdisciplinary education is well-suited to enable transformative learning, especially through its

emphasis on exposure to a wide range of knowledge and perspectives, and its focus on reflexivity (Baumber, 2022).

Unpredictable Outcomes

As mentioned earlier in the design phase, the outcomes of transdisciplinary education are not always measurable in terms of direct progress toward solving the problem. You can set output requirements to guide the process toward a solution, but the transformation during the iterative learning process may be an even more important—though less tangible—outcome.

The open-ended nature of transdisciplinary projects can be confusing and frustrating for students and other stakeholders. Traditional courses or work projects offer clear, tangible outputs or requirements, while a transdisciplinary project may never truly end.

You don't have to reinvent the wheel during the process. Multiple tools and techniques have proven useful in transdisciplinary education.

A list of useful working methods can be found on the [“How to Learn”](#) page of the design path.

References

Baumber, A. (2022). Transforming sustainability education through transdisciplinary practice. *Environment, development and sustainability*, 24(6), 7622-7639

Mezirow, J. (1981). A critical theory of adult learning and education. *Adult education*, 32(1), 3-24

Practice

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